

CHAPTER 10

THE FAMILY STRONGHOLD

The big news on February 11, 2011, was that Hosni Mubarak had called it quits. After supporting him for three decades, the United States threw him under a tank. Almost everywhere except in the Mubarak household, people rejoiced. We were surprised they had an opinion, one way or the other.

We got e-mails from strangers telling us what a “hopeful” development this was . . . or how “free elections” might be coming next.

Typical was the report in the *Washington Post*: “Mubarak became the second Arab leader in a month to succumb to his people’s powerful thirst for freedom.”¹

“Thirst for freedom”? If Egyptians were thirsty for freedom, they must be like camels. They need a drink of it only once every 30 years. Mubarak ruled for three decades. Egyptians went without quenching their “powerful thirst for freedom” through the 1980s, 1990s, and 2000s. Apparently, they needed to bring the cup to their lips only in 2011.

Many spoke of the “jubilant crowds” and the “idealistic youth” behind the peaceful revolution.

We were tempted to mention the jubilant crowds that attended the execution of Louis XVI, or the idealistic youth who gathered to jeer at Nicholas II when he and his family were shipped off to Yekaterinburg, where they would be murdered, along with their valet and even the cook.

Mubarak left office on Friday. The army took control on Saturday. On Sunday, the generals dissolved parliament.

Revolutions don’t always turn out well. The French Revolution was a good time to be in England. The Russian Revolution was a good time to be almost anywhere other than Russia. Even the American Revolution was a good time to be elsewhere, too. And then, when Americans finally got their freedom from Britain, they almost immediately began shackling one